

General Knowledge

Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Sungas, Kanvas and Chedis



Post Mauryan - Sungas, Kanvas and Chedis



Post-Mauryan Period (2nd Century BCE – 3rd Century AD)

- This period refers to the time between the fall of the **Mauryan Empire** and the rise of the **Gupta Empire**.
- It was marked by the emergence of regional kingdoms such as the **Shungas, Kanvas, and Chedis**.
- Several **Central Asian tribes** (Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Parthians, and Kushanas) also invaded India, transforming its political landscape.
- Significant developments occurred in **art, architecture, trade, religion, and society** during this period.

Political Developments during the Post-Mauryan Period

- The Mauryan Empire disintegrated after **Ashoka's death** due to weak successors.
- Provinces began declaring **independence** as the central authority weakened.
- **Northwest India** came under the influence of **foreign invaders**, resulting in successive invasions.
- **Kalinga** declared independence, while **Satavahanas** gained control of southern India.

- The **Shungas**, followers of **Brahmanism**, replaced the Mauryas, opposing the Buddhist policies of their predecessors.

Shunga Dynasty (185 BCE – 73 BCE)

Founded by	Pushyamitra Shunga (General of the Mauryas)
Capital	Pataliputra and Vidisha
Territory	Central and northern India up to the Narmada River

- **Pushyamitra Shunga** assassinated the last Mauryan king, **Brihadratha**, and established the Shunga dynasty.
- Shunga rulers controlled **north-central India**, resisting **Indo-Greek invasions**.
- The dynasty **protected the Gangetic Valley** from external forces.



Key Rulers of the Shunga Dynasty

1. Pushyamitra Shunga (185 BCE – 149 BCE)

- Performed **two Ashvamedha Yagnas** to assert his legitimacy (as per the **Ayodhya Inscription**).
- Defended against **Indo-Greek invasions** and **Kharavela of Kalinga**.
- Renovated **Bharhut Stupa** despite his adherence to **Brahmanism**.
- Mentioned in **Banabhatta's Harshacharita**.

2. Agnimitra Shunga (149 BCE – 141 BCE)

- His reign is known through **Kalidasa's play Malvikagnimitra**, describing his romance with Princess Malvika.
- Suppressed **rebellions in Vidarbha**.

3. Other Rulers

- **Vasumitra** defended against Indo-Greek invasions.
- **Bhagabhadra** is associated with the **Heliodorus Pillar** near Vidisha, dedicated by a Greek ambassador to **Vasudeva Krishna**.
- **Devabhuti**, the last Shunga ruler, was **assassinated** by **Vasudeva Kanva**, ending the dynasty.

Kanva Dynasty (73 BCE – 28 BCE)

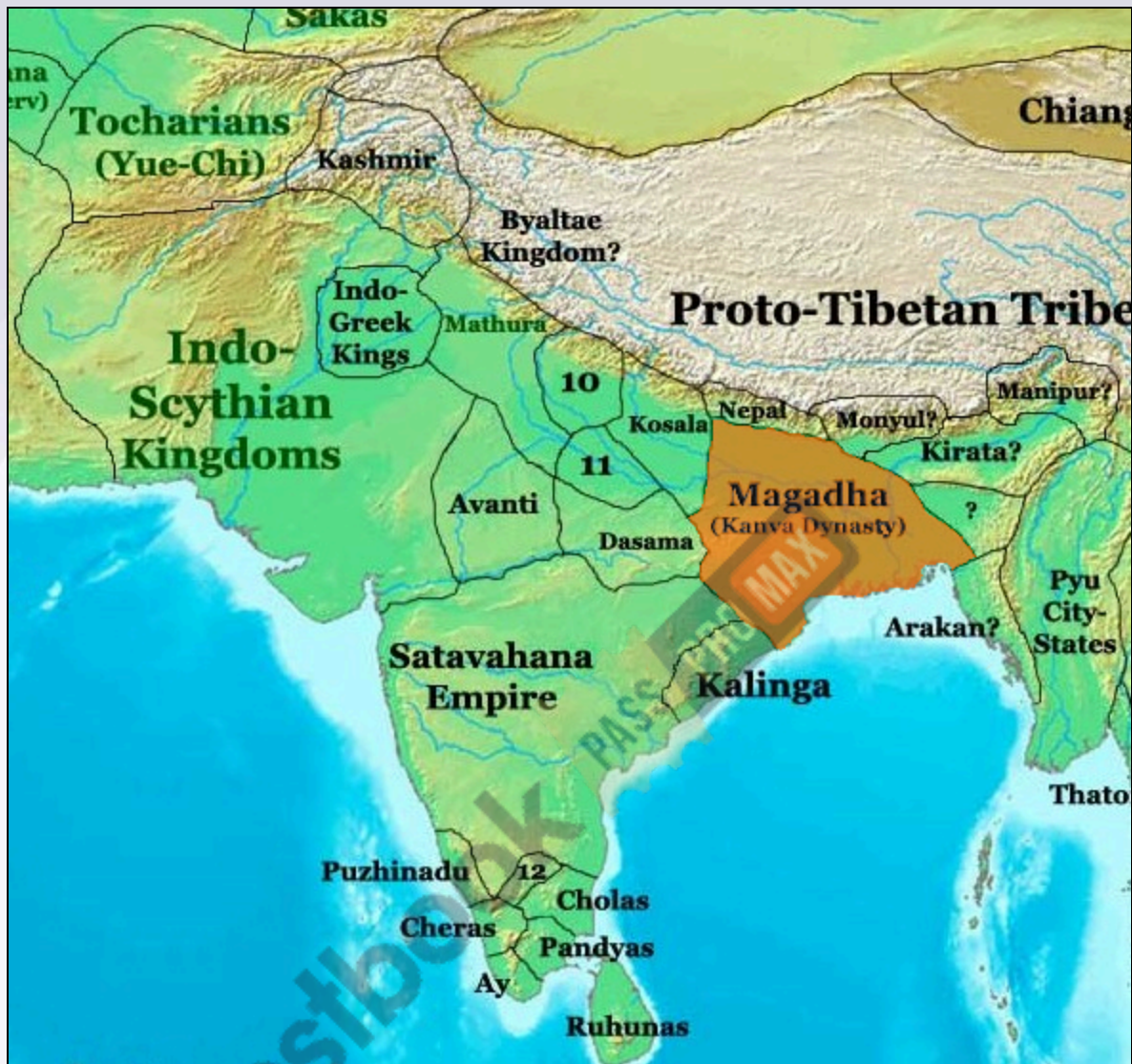
Founded by	Vasudeva Kanva (Minister of the Shunga king)
Capital	Pataliputra and Vidisha

- **Vasudeva Kanva** killed **Devabhuti** and established the Kanva dynasty.
- The Kanvas maintained the **Brahmanical traditions** and ruled much of the **Gangetic plain**.

Key Rulers of the Kanva Dynasty

1. Vasudeva Kanva (Founder)

- **Vasudeva Kanva** was originally a **Brahmin minister** in the Shunga court.
- After killing **Devabhuti**, Vasudeva retained many **administrative structures** of the Shunga dynasty to maintain continuity.
- He continued following **Brahmanical traditions** and performed **Vedic rituals**.



2. Bhumimitra

- **Bhumimitra**, the successor of Vasudeva, further strengthened the Kanva rule.
- **Coins bearing Bhumimitra's name** have been found in the **Panchala region**, indicating his sovereignty and control over the region.

3. Narayana

- **Narayana**, another ruler of the dynasty, tried to maintain the dynasty's power in the face of growing challenges.

4. Susharman (Last Ruler)

- **Susharman** was the **last ruler** of the Kanva dynasty.
- His reign ended when the **Satavahanas** overthrew him, marking the **end of the Kanva dynasty** and beginning a new era of **Satavahana rule**.

Chedi (Mahameghavahana) Dynasty (1st Century BCE)

Founded by	King Abhichandra
Capital	Suktimati-Puri (on the Suktimati River)

- The **Chedi Dynasty**, also known as the **Mahameghavahana Dynasty**, emerged in **Kalinga** after the Mauryan decline.

Key Ruler: King Kharavela

- **Kharavela** was a **Jain ruler** known for his **military conquests** and **religious patronage**.
- His achievements are recorded in the **Hathigumpha Inscription** (Brahmi script), located in the **Udayagiri hills**.
- Kharavela launched campaigns against the **Satavahanas** and expanded his territory.
- He constructed **Udayagiri and Khandagiri caves** as residences for Jain monks.
- His son **Kudepasiri** is mentioned in the **Mancapuri Cave Inscription**.

Art and Architecture during the Post-Mauryan Period

Stupas and Buddhist Architecture

Stupa	Location	Key Features
Sanchi Stupa	Vidisha, Madhya Pradesh	• Originally built by Ashoka and expanded by Shungas. • Known for elaborate Toranas and Jataka tales on gateways. • It is located on the Dakshinapatha trading route.
Bharhut Stupa	Satna, Madhya Pradesh	• Discovered by Alexander Cunningham. • Features red stone railings and narrative reliefs. • Depicts Queen Mayadevi's dream and Ruru Jataka.

Amaravati Stupa	Andhra Pradesh	- Known for intricate carvings and Buddhist narratives. - Displays floral motifs and life scenes of Buddha.
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Rock-cut Architecture

Cave Complex	Location	Key Features
Udayagiri and Khandagiri Caves	Odisha	- Built under King Kharavela. - Known for the Hathigumpha inscription in Brahmi script. Double-storey Ranigumpha Cave with exquisite sculptures.
Ajanta Caves	Maharashtra	- Early Hinayana Buddhist caves with simple architecture. - Later Mahayana caves with Buddha sculptures and paintings. - Depicts Jataka tales and royal processions.

Schools of Sculpture

School	Location	Key Features
Mathura School of Art	Mathura, Uttar Pradesh	- Known for red sandstone sculptures. - Produced early Buddha statues and Jain Tirthankara images. - Sculptures had stylised features.
Gandhara School of Art	North-West India, Pakistan	- Influenced by Greek and Roman art. - Used grey schist stone. - Created realistic Buddha images with Greek-style drapery and curly hair.

Amaravati School of Art	Andhra Pradesh	- Known for white marble sculptures. - Depicted Buddhist narratives and floral motifs. - Showcased high levels of artistic detailing.
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Contribution of Various Dynasties

Dynasty	Contribution to Art and Architecture
Shunga Dynasty	- Promoted Brahmanism but also renovated Buddhist monuments like Sanchi and Bharhut stupas. - Introduced decorated toranas (gateways).
Kanva Dynasty	- Continued Brahmanical temple construction. - Followed the artistic traditions of the Shungas.
Chedi Dynasty	- Built the Udayagiri and Khandagiri Caves. - Known for King Kharavela's patronage of Jain architecture.

Impact of Art and Architecture

- The blend of Indigenous and Foreign Traditions:** The **Gandhara School** blended **Greek, Persian, and Indian elements**.
- Religious Diversity:** Art reflected **Buddhist, Jain, and Brahmanical influences**.
- Use of Narrative Art:** Stories from religious texts were depicted in **stupas and sculptures**.
- Legacy:** The artistic styles of the post-Mauryan period influenced the **Gupta period** and beyond.

Religion and Society during the Post-Mauryan Period

- Brahmanism** regained prominence under the **Shunga dynasty**, reviving **Vedic rituals** such as the **Ashvamedha Yagna**.
- The **Varna system** became rigid, reinforcing the **social hierarchy**.
- Priests and rulers** dominated society, while **Shudras** faced continued discrimination.
- Women's roles** were restricted to domestic duties, as prescribed in **Manusmriti**.
- Mixed castes** emerged as **foreigners integrated** into Indian society.

Language and Literature of the Post-Mauryan Period

- **Sanskrit** gained prominence, becoming the language of **religious and literary texts**.
- **Patanjali** authored the **Mahabhasya** on Sanskrit grammar and **Yoga Sutras** on yoga philosophy.
- The **Brahmi script** evolved further, with connections to the Kalinga Brahmi and Maurya scripts.

Trade and Commerce during the Post-Mauryan Period

- **Merchant guilds** and **trading corporations** flourished.
- **Mathura** was known for producing **shataka cloth**.
- **Uttarapatha** and **Dakshinapatha** were major trade routes connecting different regions.
- **Monsoon winds** facilitated maritime trade with **Rome and Southeast Asia**, enhancing commerce.